The Congress believes the Seva Dal could be its answer to the RSS, a cadre-based counter taking the party's message to the villages. But after decades of neglect, can it be resurrected as a grassroots force?

By **Kaushik Deka**



ON

the night of October 31, 2026, 24 hours before the November 1 rally of the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance or the INDIA bloc, Delhi's Ramlila Maidan was a swamp. Heavy rains had left the ground waterlogged, and with thousands of Opposition workers expected in the capital, the Congress faced an embarrassing logistical crisis. Till Seva Dal chief organiser B.V. Srinivas, along with Delhi PCC president Devender Yadav and others, came to the rescue. Volunteers drained the water and dumpers filled the slushy patches with dry mud. By morning, the venue was ready, and through the day 3,000 Dal volunteers guided the people, manned the gates and served water to the thirsty.

Srinivas declines to take credit, though. "Many people credited the Seva Dal with the rally's success because our volunteers were visible on the ground. Congress leaders and our front organisations worked and planned meticulously to ensure the success," he says. For Rahul Gandhi, however, it was a glimpse of what the party's oldest volunteer organisation could do as a grassroots force. The harder question is whether a body that spent decades unrolling carpets at party sessions can become the permanent cadre he has wanted for a decade, one that can take on the ruling BJP's alma mater, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS).

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge appointed Srinivas, a 45-year-old OBC leader from Karnataka, chief organiser on June 26, replacing Lalji Desai in a reshuffle that insiders say bore Rahul's stamp. Srinivas, a former Indian Youth Congress (IYC) president known as the 'Oxygen Man' for running a volunteer command centre during the second Covid wave in 2021, brings the reputation of a street organiser who is equally at home at protest sites and seva centres.

TWO SCHOOLS OF SERVICE

Rahul reads the Congress's defeats since 2014 as a sign of organisational hollowing. The BJP's strength, in his view, rests on the RSS's vast booth-level machinery, ideological training and community networks. He wants the Seva Dal to be the "backbone and protector of the Congress ideology" and its "first line of defence". The rivalry has a history. RSS founder Keshav Baliram Hedgewar was a Seva Dal worker before he set up the RSS in Nagpur in 1925.

THE SEVA DAL'S EFFORTS AT THE RAMLILA MAIDAN RALLY SHOWED WHAT THE CONGRESS'S OLDEST VOLUNTEER ORGANISATION COULD DO IF IT REGROUPED AS A GRASSROOTS FORCE

The two differ fundamentally in their ideological roots and organisational roles, though. The Seva Dal is an arm of a political party. Its creed comes from the freedom movement: non-violence, pluralism, constitutional citizenship and service across religious and caste divisions. The RSS, by contrast, defines its mission through Hindu cultural nationalism and social organisation. Though it operates separately from the BJP, generations of its trained volunteers have entered the party's leadership and campaign machinery.

The RSS builds its cadre through routine. A swayamsevak typically begins at the local shakha, which meets for an hour every day, opens with a salute to the saffron Bhagwa Dhwaj and closes with the